

Session 15: The Covenant of Circumcision

Key Takeaways

- Hagar plays out an inverted prelude to the exodus. As an Egyptian slave fleeing oppression at the hands of Avram and Sarai, she meets God's mercy and blessing in the wilderness.
- Both Hagar and Avram face a de-creation and re-creation moment in this narrative—Hagar in wilderness and blessing, and Avram in circumcision and a new name.
- The covenant of circumcision reflects the language of God's covenant with Noah in Genesis 9. It is a sign both of God's judgment and his grace.

Yahweh Hears the Cry

The story of Yahweh hearing the cry of the oppressed and intervening to deliver and judge violent evil is an important template at work in Genesis 16. The hyperlinks to Genesis 4 and 6 portray Hagar among the righteous sufferers whose outcry reaches up to God.

At the spring (עין), Yahweh hears of the oppression (עני) of Hagar, and sends his messenger to deliver the righteous ([Gen. 16:7, 11](#)).

Genesis 4:10 Instructor's Translation

... What have you done? The voice of the shed-blood of your brother is crying out (צעק) to me from the ground.

Genesis 6:13 Instructor's Translation

An end of all flesh has come (קץ ... בא) up before me ...

Genesis 18:20-21 Instructor's Translation

The outcry (זעקה) against Sodom and Gomorrah is great ... the outcry (צעקה) has come up (באה) before me.

And in [Genesis 19:1](#), Yahweh sends his messengers to deliver the righteous.

This theme of the outcry of the oppressed rising up to God is at work in this story as well. Avraham and Sarai are portrayed as “doing violence” and “oppression” to their Egyptian slave. In each case of this design pattern, Yahweh enacts some kind of judgment against human evil.

Yahweh Hears the Cry

This story is remarkable because it follows the first mention of the future Egyptian enslavement of Israel in Genesis. The wordplay linkages are significant.

Genesis 15:13-14 Instructor's Translation

¹³ Know for certain that your seed will be **immigrants** (Heb. *ger* / גֵּר) in a land that is not theirs, and they will be enslaved to them, and they will **oppress** (Heb. *'anah* / עָנָה) them four hundred years. ¹⁴ But also that I myself will judge the nation whom to which they are slaves, and afterward they will come out with many possessions.

Genesis 16:1, 6 Instructor's Translation

¹ Now, Sarai ... had a slave-girl ... named **Hagar** (Heb. *ha-gar* / הַגֵּר = "The Immigrant")

⁶ And Sarai **oppressed** (Heb. *'anah* / עָנָה) her, and she fled.

Exodus 1:11 Instructor's Translation

And [the Egyptians] set over [the Israelites] captains of slave-labor, in order to **oppress** (עָנָה) them.

Long before the Egyptians deceived the Israelites and oppressed them, Avraham deceived Pharaoh and Sarai oppressed an Egyptian. The fact that this story precedes the exodus story means that the Egyptian slavery of Avraham's descendants becomes a tragically ironic reversal: Egypt does to Israel what Israel first did to Egypt.

There is some connection here to the laws about the treatment of immigrants in the covenant code, and the relationship to the Cain story (see [Exod. 22:21-23](#)).

Exodus 22:21-23 Instructor's Translation

²¹ You shall not wrong an immigrant (גֵּר) or oppress him, for you were immigrants in the land of Egypt. ²² You shall not oppress (עָנָה) any widow or orphan. ²³ If you intensely oppress (עָנָה תַעֲנֶה) him, and if he does cry out (צָעַק) to me, I will surely hear his outcry (צָעָקָה); ²⁴ and my anger will be hot (חַרָּה אֲפִי), and I will kill you (הָרַג) with the sword, and your wives shall become widows and your children fatherless.

Here are more links to the divided brothers pattern.

- [Genesis 16:12](#) "He will be a donkey of a man (פֶּרֶא אָדָם)" which recalls the "divided" (פֶּרֶד) motif of Noah's sons from [Genesis 10:5, 32](#).
- [Genesis 16:12b](#) "He will dwell against the face of all his brothers" is recalled in [Genesis 25:18](#), when Yishmael (Ishmael) settles in the east.

There is an important foundation being laid here for the "righteous non-elect" of the covenant family who dwells in the east. Just as many of the non-elect peoples in [Genesis 10](#) will later turn up as righteous gentiles or wicked gentiles, the same is true here with Yishmael. He and Hagar are the recipients of divine blessing ([Gen. 16:10](#) inverts [Gen. 3:16](#) and restates [Gen. 15:5](#), but now applied to Yishmael!). And while future conflict between Yishmael's descendants and Avraham's other future sons is anticipated, the oracle isn't entirely negative. Yishmael is included in the blessing of Avraham nonetheless.

Genesis 15-16 Replays Genesis 2-11 and 12-14

Genesis 2 • God's blessing of fruitful seed • Garden abundance • Sacred space of God's presence by the tree of life on Mt. Eden • Deep sleep and the provision of the delivering-help (עֲזָרָה)	Genesis 3 • Foolish failure at the tree of testing that is "good of sight" • She saw ... and took and gave • Deception and lack of trust in God's word • Exile from Eden	Genesis 4-6 • Brothers with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers "separate" through violence • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading to a flood of judgment	Violence, Flood, Remnant, Covenant (Gen. 6-9a)
Genesis 9:18-20 • Human blessing and abundance in a garden	Genesis 9:21-29 • Human folly in the garden • Sexual abuse in the tent • Family division and curse	Genesis 10:1-32 • Family, brothers divide and separate • Building of Babylon in east • Rebellion is simmering	Rebellion, Scattering, Remnant, Promise (Gen. 11)
Genesis 12:1-9 • God's blessing of abundance and protection • Promise of fruitful seed • God's presence at tree and mountains	Genesis 12:10-20 • Foolish failure with Sarai in Egypt who is "beautiful of sight" • Deception and lack of trust in God's word • Exile from false-Eden (i.e., Egypt) results in getting a slave	Genesis 13 • Brother with abundance • Jealousy and conflict • Brothers separate through non-violence! • Non-chosen brother settles in the east, where violence is simmering, leading up to a flood of judgment	Violence, Flood, Remnant, Covenant (Gen. 14)
Genesis 15:1-21 • God's blessing and promise of seed and land • Deep sleep and the provision of the seed (זָרַע)	Genesis 16:1-6 • Foolish failure with Hagar the Egyptian slave • Sarai takes and gives to her husband • And she saw ... • "Do what's good in your eyes"	Genesis 16:7-16 • Yahweh meets non-chosen rival wife in the wilderness • Promise of a son whose hand will be against all his brothers	Violence, Flood, Remnant, Covenant (Gen. 17)
<i>Genesis 15-16 As a Replay.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).			

The story has portrayed both Avram and Sarai as humans who repeat their folly. Now, as the sequence of Genesis 15-16 replays the key elements of Genesis 12-13, both Avram and Sarai replay the folly of humanity